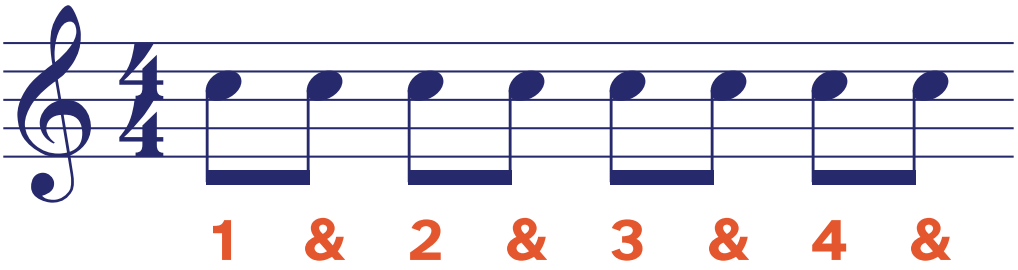
PART II · TIME · 6

Rhythm: groups and upbeats

Say your own name: long and short sounds, that's **rhythm**. The pulse marches steadily on; the rhythm dances around it. How the notes are grouped on the page shows where the beats fall.

THE SECRET

Beams group notes into beats; an upbeat borrows from the last bar.



One beam, one beat

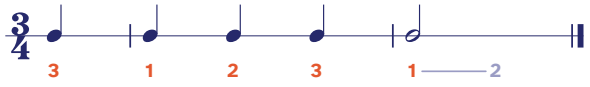
Grouping with beams

Beams join the notes of **one beat**, so the beats stay visible. In 4/4 a beam may cover beats 1–2 or 3–4, but never cross the middle of the bar (except in a deliberate grouping such as 3 + 3 + 2). In compound time, quavers are beamed in threes.

× A beam across beats 2 and 3 would hide the middle of the bar.
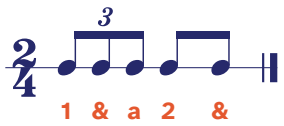
The upbeat (anacrusis)

A piece can begin **before** the first full bar, with one or more notes called an upbeat or anacrusis. The last bar is then short by the same amount, so the two together make one full bar. Count the missing beats in silence before you start.



Count "1 2" silently, then play on 3.
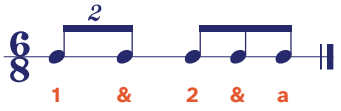
Triplets



Triplet: three exactly equal notes in the time of two. First met: Level 2.

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Duplet



Two notes in the time of three, in compound time: the triplet turned inside out.

PART II · TIME · 6 · CONTINUED



Two quavers: one beat cut in 2



A **triplet**: one beat cut in 3



Four semiquavers: one beat cut in 4

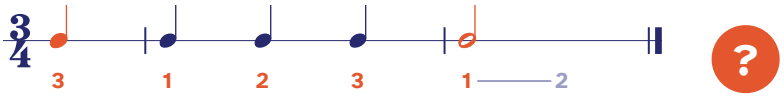
Counting smaller values



Crotchet, two quavers, four semiquavers and a triplet (“trip-o-let”): one beat each.

EXAMPLE 1

Does the upbeat balance the last bar?



1. **The upbeat:** how many beats before the first full bar?
2. **The last bar:** how many beats?
3. **Add them:** do they make a whole bar of 3/4?

1 + 2 = 3: the upbeat and the last bar **make one full bar** together.

GAME

May the beam join them?

1	2	3
beats 1 and 2	beats 2 and 3	beats 3 and 4

In 4/4, quavers are beamed so the middle of the bar stays visible. Which pairs may share one beam?

Answer: 1 yes · 2 no, that hides the middle of the bar · 3 yes.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



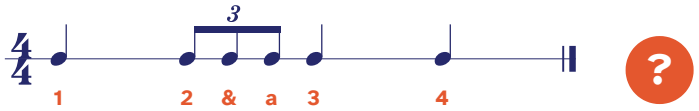
Clap “1 & 2 & 3 & 4 &”.

Now clap only the numbers, then only the &s, while your foot keeps the beat. The beat never moves; your claps do.

PART II · TIME · 6 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Where is the triplet, and how do you count it?

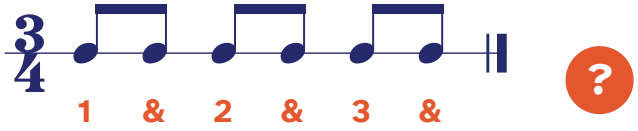


1. **Count the bar:** four crotchet beats.
2. **Find the little 3.** Which beat do the three quavers share?
3. **Say it** with “trip-o-let” on that beat.

Beat 2: “1, **trip-o-let**, 3, 4”. Three notes squeeze into one beat; the beat never moves.

EXAMPLE 3

Why are six quavers beamed in twos in 3/4?



1. **How many beats** does 3/4 have, and what kind?
2. **How many quavers** fit in one beat?
3. **So how many** go under each beam?

Three crotchet beats, two quavers each: **2 + 2 + 2**. Beamed 3 + 3 they would look like 6/8.

HOW TO

Practise triplets

1. **Say “trip-o-let”** on every beat, evenly.
2. **Clap the three syllables** while your foot keeps the beat.
3. **Switch** between two quavers (“1 &”) and a triplet (“trip-o-let”) every bar.

YOU KNOW THIS

Happy Birthday



“Hap-py” comes **before** the first strong beat: an upbeat. The strong beat lands on “birth”.

Try it. Sing it and clap only on “birth”, “day” and “you”: you feel where bar 1 starts.

THINK OF IT An upbeat is the breath before you speak: “and-ONE”. You lift on the upbeat so the strong beat can land.

SEE ALSO

Notes and rests p. 50 · Rhythm: off the beat p. 65

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Levels ½–4 · Rhythm · Online: Rhythm clock